

Joy Requires Reduced Action Coupling

Selected M-ZRT Exercises: Maximizing Effectiveness, Minimizing Difficulty

June 26, 2026

Florian Morin, florianmorin.com

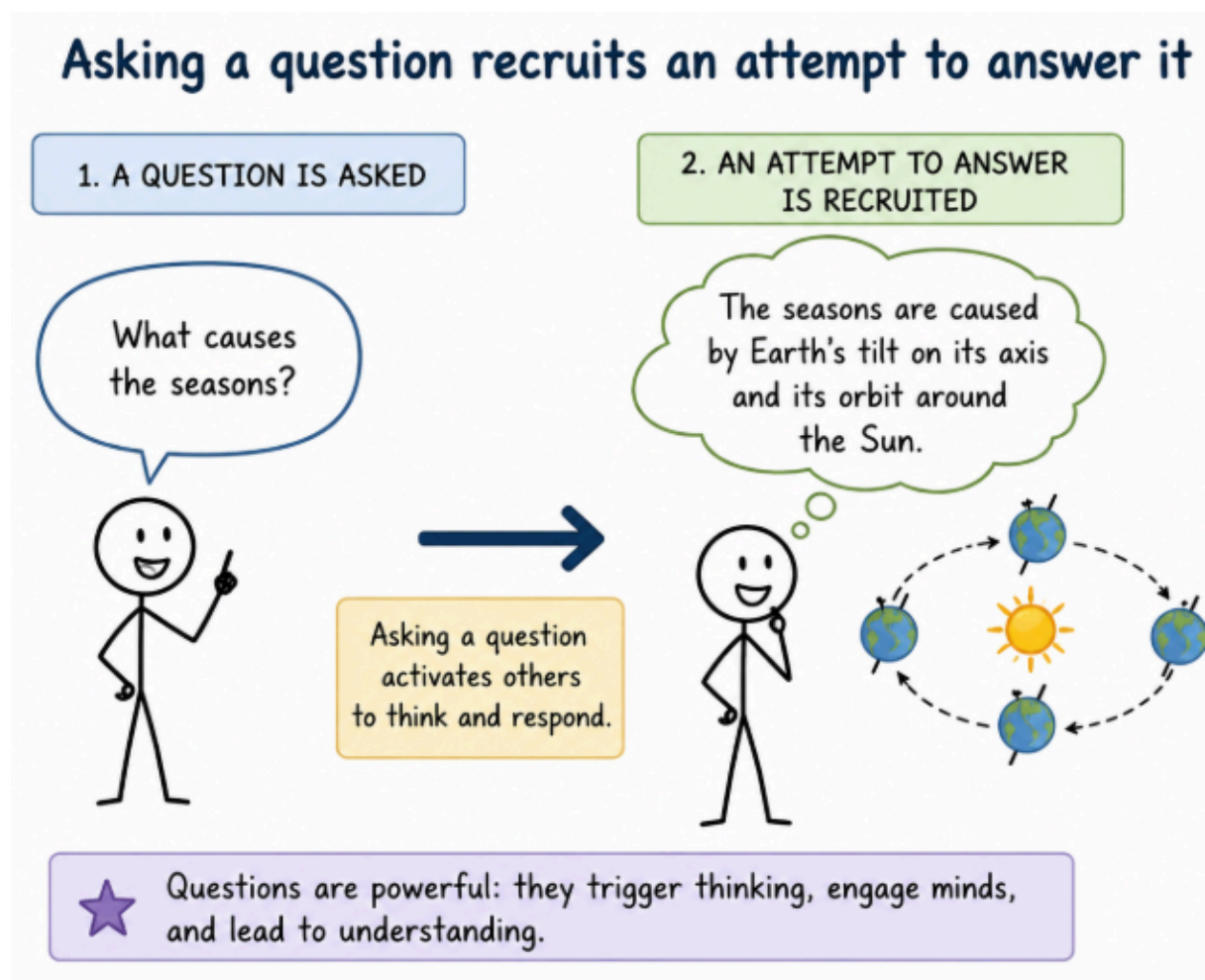
Independent Researcher

A Regime Theory of Joy

Action coupling

Action coupling refers to the tendency for one action to automatically recruit another.

Originality of the framework. To our knowledge, this is the first framework to propose action coupling as the primary variable governing access to joy and to derive a systematic set of behavioral perturbations from that principle.



Walking recruits movement toward a destination

1. WALKING IS INITIATED



Walking activates and guides the body to move forward.

2. MOVEMENT TOWARD A DESTINATION IS RECRUITED

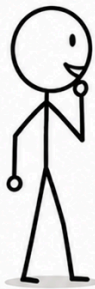


Walking doesn't just happen—it is an active process that recruits movement toward a goal.

Noticing an object recruits identification.

1. AN OBJECT IS NOTICED

Oh, look!
What's that?



Noticing gets our
attention and triggers
the process of figuring
out what something is.

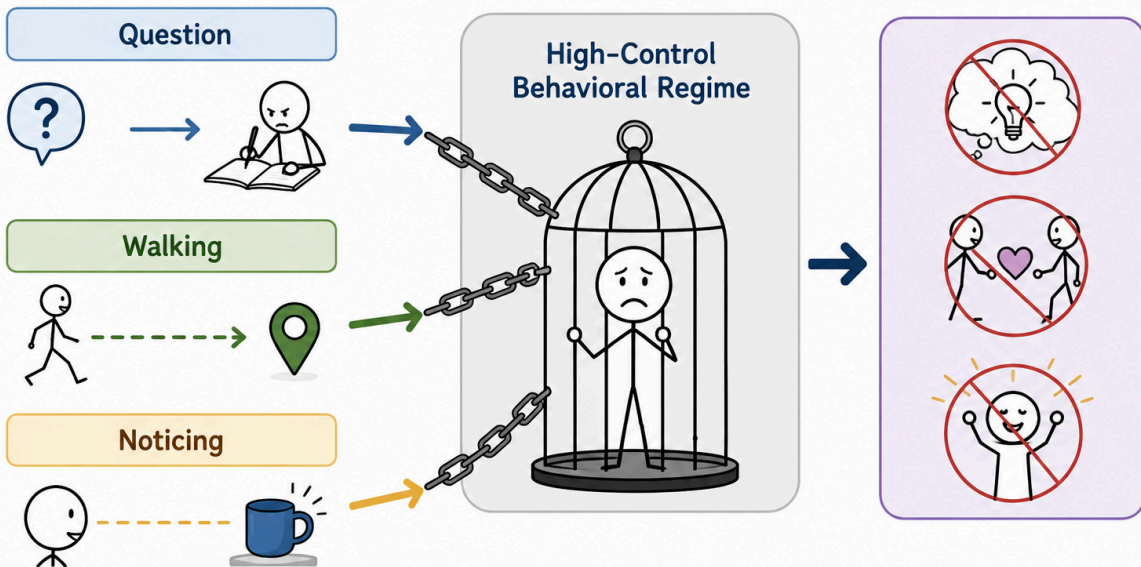
2. IDENTIFICATION IS RECRUITED

That's a mug.

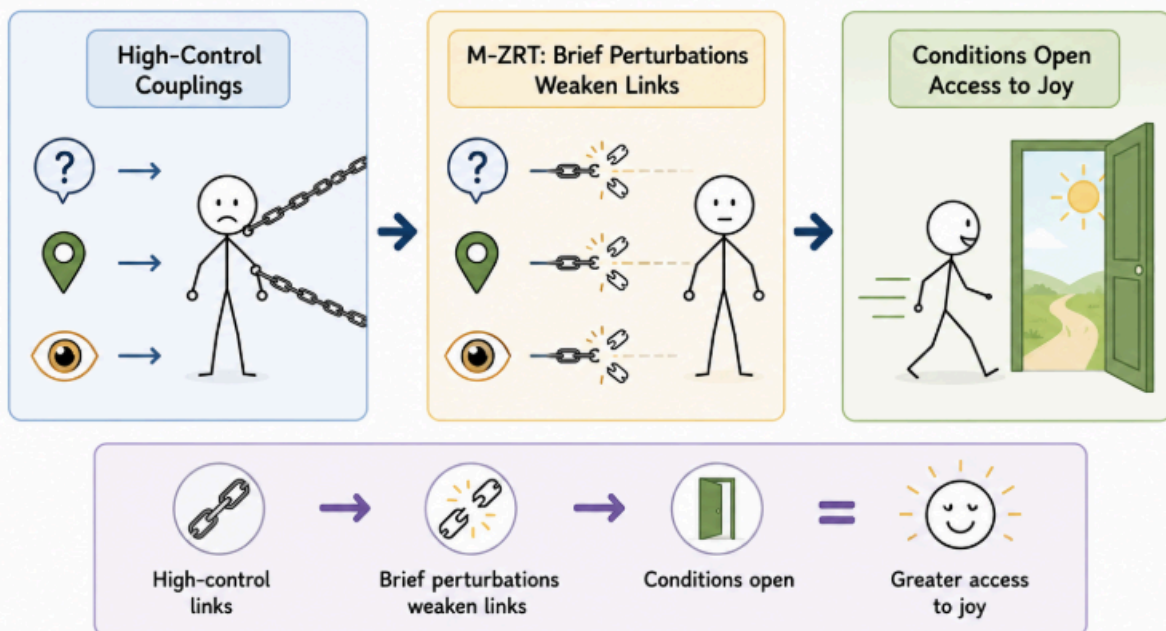


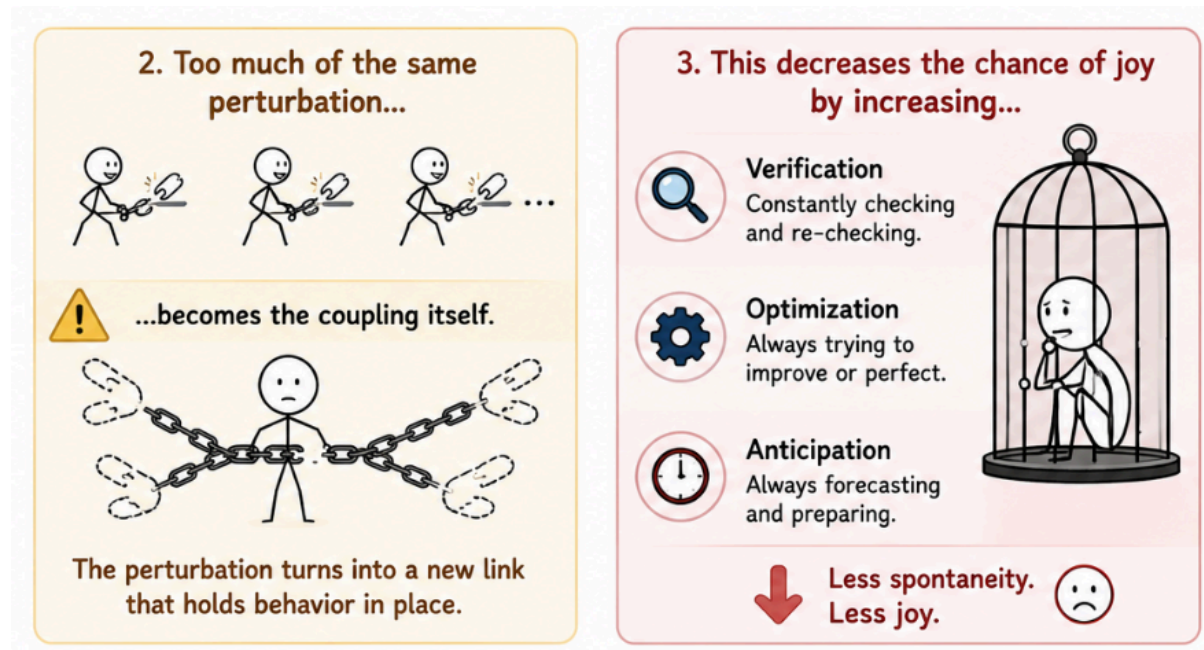
We first notice, then we identify.
Notice → Identify → Understanding

These couplings are viewed as contributors to a high-control behavioral regime.



M-ZRT therefore includes brief perturbations that selectively weaken these links, thereby creating conditions that may facilitate access to joy.





The goal of the M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task, where Z denotes evaluative load) is to reduce the coupling between an action and its expected next action.

Examples include asking a question without attempting to answer it, or making a purposeless detour while walking.

Consider the exercise "Ask a question without answering it." Now imagine that, immediately afterward, you check whether you successfully avoided answering. From an action-policy coupling perspective, this is a failure, because the exercise has become coupled to a verification policy.

Instead of the sequence ending with an unanswered question, it now continues as:

Ask question → avoid answering → verify success.

The verification step becomes the new expected action recruited by the exercise. The behavioral sequence has crystallized into a rule that recruits evaluation whenever the exercise is performed.

The objective is therefore not to "succeed" at leaving questions unanswered, but to prevent the exercise itself from reliably recruiting any particular next action, including checking whether it worked. The exercise should terminate naturally, without requiring evaluation, or completion.

We can now compare two formulations of what appears to be the same exercise and examine how each may influence next action pressure.

1. Ask a question without answering it.

This formulation explicitly instructs the participant to perform two actions: generate a question and avoid answering it. While simple, it can recruit an additional action policy centered on monitoring whether the instruction has been followed. The sequence may become:

Ask a question → avoid answering → check whether I successfully avoided answering.

The participant may repeatedly evaluate whether they are "doing it correctly." Because each evaluation can recruit verification, error detection, and corrective adjustments, it generates additional candidate actions, thereby increasing next action pressure.

2. Small Curiosity

Let a small curiosity arise, such as "Why this color?" or "What if I turned left?" Do not try to answer it.

"Let a curiosity arise" frames the question as something that appears rather than something that must be deliberately produced. Likewise, "Do not *try* to answer it" avoids implying that success must later be verified. As a result, the cognitive sequence is more likely to terminate naturally after the question appears, without recruiting an additional verification policy.

Although both formulations describe a similar observable behavior, they may differ substantially in the amount of next action pressure they generate.

We will now use this reasoning to explore how to reduce next action pressure in an RPG video game by remaining within the game's town and avoiding combat and quests, since both naturally increase next action pressure.



There are three types of exercises: Suspension, Openness, and Salience.

Each targets a different component of **next action pressure**, **reducing it** through a distinct mechanism. This is important because, once next action pressure is sufficiently lowered, the probability of experiencing *joy* increases.

The M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task) is the task presented below. It is designed to reduce Z, where Z refers to accumulated next-action pressure.

Joy is a distinct positive affect class. It is not “reward but louder”. It is a kind of affective quietude where it happens without excitement, with altered sensations, in a non-addictive, yet strongly positive way. Radiating chest-pleasure and increased olfaction are core features of joy.



These exercises can also be performed in video games. RPGs and enemy-free FPS games are particularly suitable because they contain many of the elements these exercises naturally interact with, such as doors, corridors, intersections, and small objects. When possible, remain in towns, hubs, or other peaceful areas where little or no gameplay challenge is present.

You can also choose one or two exercises and use each monster pack in an RPG as a cue to perform one of them. This way, the exercises become naturally embedded in gameplay and are sufficiently spaced apart, allowing the brain time to process each one before the next occurs.

Before the first exercise, note that each session lasts only 2 to 3 minutes, and two sessions per day are sufficient. This limitation is important because the temptation to do more, to extend the session, or to optimize the task by trying to perform it “better” can itself increase next-action pressure.

According to the model, trying to “win” makes entry into joy less likely. It is therefore preferable to perform an imperfect session than to optimize the task, because attempting to maximize success can undermine the very conditions the task is designed to create. A failed session is one in which verification, anticipation, and performance monitoring become the dominant drivers of behavior, thereby increasing next-action pressure.

After each session, you can check for any effect by watching music videos that you already enjoy, especially those that are energetic or emotionally engaging. They tend to make changes in subjective experience more noticeable. Keep in mind that entry is probabilistic, so a given session may produce no noticeable effect. However, once entry has occurred clearly at least once, subsequent re-entry often becomes much easier, and may sometimes occur spontaneously. For this reason, the initial investment of time and commitment is worthwhile.

Why Alter Your Path Is Harder Than It Looks

Description:

Alter Your Path is a classic M-ZRT exercise. Whenever a movement plan begins to feel established, introduce a small arbitrary deviation. For example, circle a harmless object, take a short detour, or alter your trajectory for a moment before resuming normal movement. The deviation should remain brief.

Because movement opportunities occur constantly in RPGs, this exercise can be performed repeatedly throughout a play session.

Imagine you are about to pick up an object. Just before touching it, you realize it is hot. You immediately stop the movement and do not complete the action. “Not so fast”, you may think. The action sequence was already underway, but it was interrupted before completion.

Visually, it produces a somewhat unusual sequence, which you can see here: <https://youtu.be/kFQZ4VsY1sw?si=k9tMHf5Vc6FZByNz&t=69>. It appears strange because the player is repeatedly interrupting the ongoing action. As a result, they take a few steps, stop, turn slightly, continue, then interrupt the movement again a moment later.

Alter Your Path is interesting precisely because it reveals how strongly an ongoing sequence can become self-protective. The exercise simply introduces a small deviation to observe how much resistance is generated by something that has no practical cost.

In fact, if a one-second detour feels surprisingly difficult, that is itself evidence that the action sequence has acquired a degree of automatic momentum. From an M-ZRT perspective, this is relevant because the proposed access regime for joy is characterized by greater flexibility in how actions, predictions, and attentional commitments are recruited and maintained.

Why use a video-game?

In real life, a deviation often carries a practical cost. Taking a detour means walking farther, spending more time, using more energy, and sometimes attracting attention. The brain therefore has more reasons to protect the ongoing trajectory.

There is also the issue of fatigue. If you perform Alter Your Path twenty times while walking through a city, it quickly becomes more demanding.

Above all, in an RPG you can see the action chain itself much more clearly. You are watching an avatar move across the screen. When the avatar deviates, the interruption of continuity is highly visible. In real life, you are inside the action. The change of direction may be experienced more as a physical inconvenience than as a disruption of an ongoing sequence.

Are some games like *Breath of the Wild* naturally M-ZRTs? Not really.

The difference is that in *Breath of the Wild*, deviation is already rewarded and intentionally designed into the game. It becomes part of an exploration loop. The player leaves the path because something interesting appears.

In M-ZRT, the idea is more minimal. The deviation is not performed for a sufficient reason, a clear reward, or a new objective. The point is simply to introduce a small disruption into an ongoing action sequence without immediately rebuilding another goal structure around it.

Why Alter Your Path Is Harder Than It Looks

On paper, "Alter Your Path" appears trivial. Slightly changing direction for a second seems much simpler than solving a problem, meditating, or learning a skill.

Mechanically, however, the exercise intervenes directly in a chain that has already been recruited:

chosen direction → path prediction → motor adjustments → destination

For many people, once an action has been initiated, it becomes automatically protected. The continuity of the action is experienced as the "normal" trajectory, and any deviation, even a tiny one, can create a sense of strangeness or pointlessness.

What is interesting is that many people find it easier to perform a complicated task than to introduce a small arbitrary disruption into an action that is already underway.

For example, some people will have less difficulty:

- solving a puzzle for ten minutes,
- planning a trip,
- learning a game rule,

than:

- walking for two seconds in a slightly different direction,
- abandoning a click that has already been initiated,
- leaving a mental sentence unfinished.

Alter Your Path is simply:

"You were going right, go slightly left for a second, then continue."

The problem is that many people immediately start looking for:

- the optimal duration,
- the expected effect,
- how to know whether they succeeded,
- when to trigger it,
- why this deviation rather than another.

In other words, they reconstruct a layer of rules around an exercise that was specifically intended to remain minimal.

There is also another issue: many people do not directly perceive the ongoing action chain itself. They only see the physical movement. When I say, "slightly alter your path," they hear, "make a strange movement." They do not see that the target of the exercise is the continuity of the behavioral sequence.

It is also possible that the exercise falls outside common intuition. Most psychological exercises ask people to add something: think, observe, analyze, breathe, visualize, focus. Alter Your Path does the opposite. It asks for a small arbitrary disruption within something that is already in progress.

Many people have almost never done this deliberately, so they do not possess a ready-made mental category for understanding the instruction.

Catalog

According to M-ZRT criteria, these exercises are among the most practical because they act on already ongoing perception-action sequences, require minimal cognitive construction, and generate little pressure to evaluate their outcome. This combination tends to reduce implementation difficulty while preserving their potential effect on next action pressure.

One-Word Drift

Look at an object. Let one unrelated word pass through.

Chair → moon

Cursor → bird

The object and the word merely touch briefly in awareness. Because the word appears and disappears quickly, the exercise can be performed with almost no cognitive effort.

Object → Stable meaning → Action recruitment

becomes

Object → Unrelated word contact → Openness → Return

One of the strengths of the exercise is its minimality. Because the word appears and disappears quickly, there is little opportunity for explanation, imagination, or analysis.

For a moment, the object's usual meaning is no longer the only available possibility. Perception opens slightly without settling anywhere else. Then normal perception resumes.

Exercise: Object Without a Task

Description: Briefly notice an object without immediately relating it to a use or purpose. Then continue normally.

So:

Object → Purpose → Function → Action recruitment

Becomes

Object → Purpose temporarily less important → Return

Normally, many objects are perceived through the actions they support. Their practical role becomes central almost immediately.

This exercise briefly weakens that process.

Exercise: Wrong But Unknown

Description: Briefly notice that something about the object seems wrong, without identifying what. Then continue normally.

For a brief moment:

- Chair → Something is wrong
- Door → Something is wrong
- Tree → Something is wrong
- Icon → Something is wrong

But:

- No explanation
- No diagnosis
- No correction
- No search

So:

Object → Detect mismatch → Explain mismatch → Resolve mismatch

briefly becomes:

Object → Detect mismatch → Mismatch remains unspecified → Return

Exercise: Not Quite What It Is

Description: Look at an ordinary object and briefly experience it as not entirely matching its usual category. Then let the impression disappear.

For a brief moment:

- Chair → Not quite a chair
- Lamp → Not quite a lamp
- Tree → Not quite a tree
- Icon → Not quite an icon

So:

Object → Category → Meaning → Action recruitment

briefly becomes:

Object → Slight category mismatch → Openness → Return

Normally, familiar objects are rapidly assigned to stable categories. Once categorization occurs, associated meanings, expectations, and potential actions are recruited automatically.

A chair becomes something to sit on. A door becomes something to pass through. An icon becomes something to click.

This exercise briefly loosens that process. The object remains recognizable, but its category feels slightly less complete than usual. Nothing replaces the category, and no alternative explanation is required.

Categories function as prediction shortcuts. Once an object is confidently classified, a large network of expectations becomes available automatically. By weakening the certainty of categorization, the exercise briefly reduces the recruitment of those expectations.

Exercise: This Doesn't Quite Fit

Description: Look at an ordinary object. For a moment, let it seem slightly out of place. Do not explain why. Then continue normally.

Familiar objects are rapidly integrated into a coherent interpretation of the environment. Their role, location, and significance become immediately understandable, allowing perception to support ongoing action.

For example:

- Chair → belongs in the room
- Door → belongs in the wall
- Lamp → belongs on the desk
- Icon → belongs in the interface

This stable fit helps recruit expectations about what can happen next.

So:

Object → Interpretation → Action recruitment → Next action pressure

briefly becomes:

Object → Slight mismatch → Interpretation remains open → Return

One of the strengths of the exercise is its ambiguity. The mismatch remains open and undefined.

For a moment, the object is present without fully settling into a completed interpretation. Because no explanation is selected, no particular continuation becomes privileged.

Then normal perception resumes.

Exercise: Sentence That Doesn't Finish

Description: A sentence begins internally and then loses momentum before reaching its end. Nothing needs to replace it.

For a brief moment:

"Maybe the reason is..."

"I should probably..."

"The important thing is..."

Exercise: Incomplete Caption

Description: Looking at something, an internal description starts but remains unfinished.

Example:

"This is a..."

For a brief moment:

Chair → "This is a..."

Lamp → "This is a..."

Tree → "This is a..."

Normally: Perception → Identification → Description → Meaning stabilization

Here: Perception → Partial description → No completion → Return

Exercise: Unfinished Meaning

Description: Something feels as though it could be interpreted or understood further. The interpretation does not occur.

For a brief moment:

Object → Could be understood further → No interpretation

Event → Could be explained → No interpretation

Normally: Perception → Interpretation → Meaning stabilization → Next thought recruitment

Unfinished Meaning: Perception → Interpretation possible → No interpretation → Return

Question Without Search

Description: A question appears internally. Do not answer it, but also do not suppress it.

Question → No search → No answer → Return

The interruption occurs at the moment where the mind would normally begin searching for an answer.

Unlike active thought suppression, the question is not pushed away. It remains present for a moment. What is absent is the automatic recruitment of explanation, memory retrieval, prediction, or analysis.

One of the strengths of the exercise is that it directly targets a very common cognitive sequence. Questions naturally recruit search processes. Once the search begins, additional

thoughts, evaluations, and plans often follow. This exercise interrupts the sequence at its earliest stage.

Time-Checking

Exercise: One Time Among Others

Description: After checking the time, briefly notice that many other times exist as well. Then continue normally.

For a brief moment:

11:24

3:17

8:42

17:05

So:

Current time → Exclusive focus

becomes

Current time → Part of a larger set → Return

The goal is not to compare times. The goal is simply to reduce the feeling that the displayed time deserves exclusive attention.

Exercise: Arbitrary Time

Description: After checking the time, briefly think of another unrelated clock time, such as 3:17, 8:42, or 11:06. Then continue normally.

Normally:

Current time → Scheduling → Estimation → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Current time → Arbitrary time → Return

Checking the time often recruits future-oriented processing. The current time immediately becomes linked to deadlines, plans, delays, productivity, upcoming activities, or evaluations of progress. A simple glance at the clock can therefore trigger a surprisingly large action chain.

Exercise: Another Possible Time

Description: After seeing the current time, briefly imagine a different time appearing on the display instead.

Normally

11:24 → 7:13

The exercise briefly becomes:

Displayed time → Fixed reality → Recruitment

becomes

Displayed time + Alternative possibility → Openness → Return

The goal is not to imagine a different day or different circumstances. Only the displayed numbers change.

One of the strengths of the exercise is that it introduces a small opening without requiring any narrative.

The actual time remains fully available.

Exercise: Small Curiosity

Description: After seeing the time, allow a brief curiosity such as "Already?" or "Really?" to appear. Do not answer it. Then continue normally.

Normally:

Time → Scheduling → Estimation → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Time → Small curiosity → Return

Looking at the time often recruits planning, evaluation, and future-oriented thinking. The clock rapidly becomes linked to deadlines, productivity, lateness, available time, or upcoming activities.

This exercise inserts a very small moment of curiosity before those processes fully develop. The curiosity is not a question to solve. It is simply a brief opening.

For example:

14:23 → "Already?"

09:51 → "Really?"

18:07 → "Huh."

The curiosity is intentionally incomplete. No explanation is required. No conclusion is needed. The moment remains unresolved and then disappears.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the automatic transition from time perception to action preparation. Rather than:

Time → "What should I do next?" → Planning → Action

the exercise briefly becomes:

Time → Curiosity → No answer → Return

This creates a small interruption in the recruitment chain without requiring any explicit effortful control.

Exercise: Wide Vision

Description: For a few seconds, allow attention to include more than the central point of focus. The primary object remains visible, but surrounding objects, colors, shapes, and movement are also allowed to remain present.

Normally:

Target → Focus narrowing → Action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Target → Wider visual field → Return

Many activities naturally recruit narrow visual focus. Attention becomes concentrated on the object most relevant to the current action, while the rest of the visual field becomes functionally secondary.

This exercise briefly loosens that narrowing. The central object remains available, but attention is allowed to spread across a larger portion of the scene.

For example:

Reading a screen → screen + room

Walking → path + surroundings

Holding an object → object + nearby environment

The goal is not to look around or search for details. Nothing new needs to be identified. The visual field simply becomes slightly less organized around a single target.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the tendency for a single task-relevant object to dominate perception and recruit the next step of behavior. Rather than:

Target → Action → Next action

the exercise briefly becomes:

Target → Wider scene → Return

Because action recruitment often begins with attentional narrowing, the exercise acts relatively early in the recruitment process.

Description: Cursor Passing

Description: Let the cursor pass over an object, NPC, skill, menu option, or button without selecting it.

Normally:

Target appears → Evaluation → Possible selection → Action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Target appears → Cursor passes → Continue

In many interfaces, cursor movement is tightly coupled to selection. As soon as an interesting object, button, NPC, skill, or menu option appears, attention automatically begins evaluating whether it should be clicked, opened, inspected, purchased, or used. The target recruits a potential action simply by being available.

This exercise briefly interrupts that process. The cursor passes over the target without selecting it. Nothing is rejected. Nothing is resisted. The target simply remains unselected while activity continues normally.

For example:

NPC → cursor passes → continue

Inventory item → cursor passes → continue

Skill icon → cursor passes → continue

Menu option → cursor passes → continue

The goal is not to avoid selecting things. Most targets will still be selected later if needed. The exercise only introduces a brief moment where visibility does not immediately become action.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens one of the most common recruitment chains in games and interfaces:

Visible option → Evaluation → Selection

becomes:

Visible option → Presence → Continue

Because the option remains available without requiring immediate resolution, the pressure to convert perception into action is temporarily reduced.

Exercise: The Action Ends There

Description: A small action reaches its end and remains there briefly before anything else becomes important.

Normally:

Action → Completion → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action → Completion → End remains present → Return

Most actions are experienced primarily as transitions toward subsequent actions. Their endings often disappear almost instantly because attention is already moving toward what follows.

This exercise briefly allows the endpoint itself to remain present. The action does not need to justify itself through a larger sequence. It simply reaches its end.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise creates a temporary interruption in the automatic propagation of action recruitment. The action chain stops locally rather than immediately extending itself into the future.

Exercise: Just This Action

Description: For a moment, a small action exists on its own.

Normally:

Action → Goal → Larger sequence → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action → Action → Return

Many actions are experienced primarily through the larger plans they support. Opening a door leads somewhere. Clicking a button serves another task. Picking up an object prepares a future movement.

This exercise briefly reduces the importance of those larger structures. The action is experienced locally rather than as part of an ongoing chain.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the tendency for every action to automatically recruit future actions through purpose and continuation. The action briefly stands on its own before normal behavior resumes.

Exercise: The Action Is Enough

Description: Briefly experience a small action as complete in itself.

Normally:

Action → Incomplete → Larger purpose → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action → Complete → Return

Many everyday actions are automatically interpreted as fragments of larger goals. Their value comes from what they help produce rather than from their completion itself.

This exercise temporarily suspends that assumption. The action does not need to lead somewhere else in order to be complete. Nothing additional is required for the action to count as finished.

In terms of next action pressure, this directly targets one of the strongest sources of recruitment: the feeling that the current action remains incomplete until it contributes to a future outcome. By allowing the action to feel sufficient on its own, the pressure to immediately recruit the next action is temporarily reduced.

Exercise: Local Action

Description: A small action occurs without needing to connect immediately to anything else.

Normally:

Action → Larger purpose → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action → Local action → Return

Much of everyday behavior is organized around action chains. A movement is interpreted through what it leads to, a click through the next screen, a step through the destination, a choice through its consequences. As a result, even very small actions tend to recruit larger plans and future actions almost immediately.

This exercise briefly weakens that process. The action remains local. It does not need to be integrated into a broader sequence right away. The larger purpose may still exist, but it becomes temporarily less important than the action itself.

For example:

Pick up a cup → cup in hand

Click a button → click completed

Take a step → step completed

Open a door → door opened

The emphasis is not on stopping action, but on reducing the automatic expansion of the action into future requirements.

Rather than:

Action A → Action B → Action C

the exercise briefly becomes:

Action A → Action A completed → Return

The action remains a local event instead of immediately becoming a transition toward something else. This makes Local Action one of the more direct suspension exercises for reducing continuous action recruitment while remaining easy to integrate into ordinary activities.

Exercise: Non-Strategic Click

Description: Make one click that is not chosen for its usefulness. The click should remain harmless and ordinary. Afterward, continue normally.

Normally:

Option evaluation → Best click → Action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Click → Return

Many clicks are preceded by a rapid selection process. Even when the decision is trivial, the mind often evaluates alternatives, predicts outcomes, and chooses the option that best serves the current objective.

- Click an unimportant menu category before the relevant category.
- Select a harmless interface element before continuing the task.
- Briefly focus a window that was not the most useful choice.

The click is not random for the sake of randomness, nor intentionally bad. It simply escapes the normal optimization process.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the coupling between evaluation and action selection. Rather than:

Options → Comparison → Best action → Next action recruitment

the exercise briefly becomes:

Options → Click → Return

Because action planning often begins with selecting the "correct" next action, the exercise temporarily reduces the dominance of optimization over behavior.

Exercise: One Among Several

Description: Select one option from several possibilities. Let the other options remain possible for a moment. No comparison needs to be completed afterward.

Normally:

Several options → Evaluation → Best option → Other options discarded → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Several options → One option selected → Other options remain possible → Return

When multiple options are available, the mind often attempts to establish a winner. The selected option becomes "the correct one," while the others are mentally closed, rejected, or forgotten. This process naturally recruits evaluation, prediction, and outcome monitoring.

This exercise briefly interrupts that closure

For example:

- Choosing one path in a game while the other paths remain conceivable.
- Selecting one menu entry without concluding it was the best choice.
- Talking to one NPC without mentally closing the possibility of the others.
- Picking one item from several acceptable items.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the tendency for selection to automatically recruit justification and commitment. Rather than:

Options → Best option → Confirmation → Next action chain

the exercise briefly becomes:

Options → One option → Other possibilities remain open → Return

Because many action chains begin with the feeling that a single option must become dominant, the exercise temporarily reduces the pressure created by exclusive commitment.

Exercise: Slightly Slow Down Without Reason

Description: For a few steps, walking happens at a slower pace.

Normally:

Destination → Efficient movement → Arrival → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Walking → Slight slowdown → Walking

When moving toward a destination, behavior is often organized around continuous progress. Walking speed naturally becomes coupled to efficiency, arrival time, and the next intended action. Even small movements tend to be recruited by the logic of reaching somewhere.

The slowdown should remain small enough that it feels ordinary. The goal is not to walk slowly. The goal is only to momentarily loosen the coupling between movement and optimization.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the automatic link between movement and future completion. Rather than:

Destination → Fastest acceptable movement → Arrival

the exercise briefly becomes:

Destination → Slight slowdown → Continue

The destination remains unchanged, but its ability to fully determine the movement is temporarily reduced.

Exercise: Different Side

Description: For a moment, the other side of the street becomes equally acceptable.

Normally:

Current side → Preferred side → Continue

The exercise briefly becomes:

Current side ↔ Other side → Equal acceptability → Continue

When moving through an environment, attention often organizes itself around small preferences and micro-optimizations. One side of the street appears slightly better, more convenient, more direct, more interesting, or simply more familiar. Once that preference forms, it naturally recruits behavior.

This exercise briefly weakens that recruitment. The goal is not to cross the street or to force a different choice. The goal is only to allow the alternative side to become equally acceptable for a moment.:

Left side → acceptable

Right side → acceptable

No comparison needs to be completed.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise targets the early stage where preference automatically becomes action. Normally:

Preference → Selection → Movement

The exercise briefly becomes:

Preference → Multiple acceptable options → Continue

Because no option becomes uniquely privileged, the pressure to immediately resolve the comparison is slightly reduced. The exercise therefore acts as a very lightweight suspension of automatic action recruitment, similar to Equal Options but applied to physical navigation rather than explicit decisions.

Exercise: Abort an Action

Description: Begin a simple action, then briefly stop early and continue with something else.

Normally:

Action initiation → Completion → Next action

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action initiation → Interruption → Return

Much of everyday behavior consists of continuously recruited action sequences. Once an action begins, its completion often becomes automatically expected. Reaching for an object recruits grasping it. Moving toward a menu recruits opening it. Beginning a click recruits finishing the click.

This exercise temporarily interrupts that process. A simple action begins, but completion is not treated as inevitable. The action is abandoned before reaching its endpoint, after which normal activity resumes.

For example:

Reach toward an object → stop → continue

Move toward a doorway → stop → continue

Begin opening a menu → stop → continue

Start moving in one direction → stop → choose another direction

The goal is not to create frustration or prevent actions from occurring. Most actions should still be completed normally. The exercise merely introduces occasional interruptions into otherwise automatic action chains.

In terms of next action pressure, this is one of the most direct suspension exercises.

Normally:

Action A → Action B → Action C

Once Action A begins, Action B is already partially recruited.

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action A → interruption

The recruited continuation fails to arrive. For a moment, the automatic coupling between initiation and completion weakens. Because action chains are a major source of continuous recruitment, the exercise directly targets the mechanism that generates immediate future-oriented pressure.

Exercise: Drink a Sip of Coffee

Description: Take a single sip of coffee and briefly notice the interruption it creates. Then continue normally.

Normally:

Activity → Continuous recruitment → Next action pressure

The exercise briefly becomes:

Activity → Sip of coffee → Return

Many events occurring during an activity are immediately absorbed into the ongoing action sequence. They either become irrelevant background or recruit additional actions. A sip of coffee often occupies an unusual middle position. It is salient enough to briefly interrupt the current action stream, yet usually too small to generate an entirely new chain of goals.

For a moment, the sip exists as a local event. Attention shifts toward it briefly, then returns naturally to the previous activity.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise may temporarily disrupt ongoing recruitment without strongly replacing it with a new source of recruitment. The choice of coffee is therefore coherent with the hypothesis that some mildly salient events can act as local interruptions while remaining relatively poor generators of additional action chains.

The intended sequence is:

Activity → Sip → Return

rather than:

Activity → Sip → Evaluation → Optimization → New plan

Exercise: Small Curiosity

Description: Briefly notice a small question, possibility, or detail without trying to resolve it immediately.

Normally:

Curiosity → Information seeking → Answer → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Curiosity → Curiosity remains open → Return

Many forms of curiosity automatically recruit action. A question appears, attention moves toward resolution, information is gathered, and a new action sequence begins. The curiosity rapidly becomes a task.

This exercise interrupts that transition at an early stage. A small curiosity is allowed to exist without being immediately converted into investigation.

For example:

"I wonder what's behind that door."

"I wonder what that sound was."

"I wonder why that building looks different."

The question remains briefly present, but no attempt is made to answer it.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise targets one of the most common sources of spontaneous recruitment. Curiosity naturally generates future-oriented behavior because unanswered questions create potential action paths. By allowing a minor curiosity to remain unresolved for a moment, the automatic transition from question to action is weakened.

The intended sequence is:

Curiosity → Open question → Return

rather than:

Curiosity → Search → Resolution → New action

Difficulté : 3/10

The exercise is simple to understand but slightly harder than many suspension exercises because curiosity is naturally self-recruiting. The urge to resolve the question can appear almost immediately.

Exercise: Thought Fragment

Description: A small piece of thought appears, but not enough to become a full idea.

Examples:

"Tomorrow..."

"That menu..."

"The quest..."

"Maybe..."

"This could..."

Continue normally.

Normally:

Thought beginning → Development → Full thought → Evaluation → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Thought beginning → Fragment → Return

Many thoughts begin as small fragments before expanding into predictions, plans, memories, explanations, or decisions. Once the fragment appears, the mind often automatically completes it and recruits whatever actions, evaluations, or simulations follow from it.

This exercise interrupts that process very early. The fragment is allowed to appear, but it is not developed into a complete thought. Nothing needs to replace it. The unfinished beginning simply remains incomplete and fades naturally.

For example:

"Tomorrow..." → continue

"That quest..." → continue

"I should..." → continue

The goal is not suppression. The fragment is allowed to exist. The only difference is that its continuation is not automatically recruited.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise acts before a complete action policy has formed. Normally:

Thought fragment → Completed thought → Future simulation → Action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Thought fragment → No completion → Return

Because the thought never reaches a fully specified conclusion, fewer future actions become activated. The fragment remains a local cognitive event rather than becoming the starting point of a larger chain.

Exercise: Description: No Checking

Description: After completing a simple action, do not immediately verify its outcome. For example, after placing an object on a table, resist the brief impulse to check whether it is exactly where intended. Continue directly with the next activity.

Normally:

Action → Completion → Verification → Correction if needed → Next action recruitment

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action → Completion → No checking → Continue

Many everyday actions do not end when the action itself is completed. Instead, they recruit a second sequence dedicated to verification. An object is placed, then checked. A door is closed, then checked. A click occurs, then checked. A message is sent, then checked.

This verification often feels automatic because it reduces uncertainty. However, it also extends the action chain beyond the original action. The completion recruits monitoring, which can recruit correction, which can recruit further monitoring.

This exercise briefly interrupts that process. The action is allowed to remain completed without immediate confirmation.

For example:

Place a cup on a table → continue

Close a drawer → continue

Put an item in a bag → continue

Click a button → continue

The goal is not to ignore important errors or become careless. The exercise simply targets low-consequence situations where checking has become habitual.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens one of the most common forms of post-action recruitment. Normally:

Action → "Did it work?" → Verification → Possible correction

The exercise briefly becomes:

Action → Completion → Continue

By preventing the automatic transition toward verification, the action chain terminates earlier. The completion is accepted without requiring immediate confirmation, reducing the amount of future-oriented recruitment generated by the original action.

Exercise: Wall as Presence

Description: A nearby wall simply becomes perceptibly present for a second.

Normally:

Wall → Background → Ignored

The exercise briefly becomes:

Wall → Presence → Return

Most familiar objects rapidly lose perceptual salience. Once identified as irrelevant to the current activity, they become part of the unnoticed background. A wall is usually perceived only to the degree necessary for navigation.

This exercise briefly reverses that process. Nothing is imagined. Nothing is analyzed. The wall does not become unusual, meaningful, or interesting. It simply becomes present.

For a moment:

Wall → Present

Then continue normally.

The exercise does not require sustained attention. The wall does not become a meditation object. It merely receives a brief increase in perceptual presence before returning to ordinary background status.

Exercise: The King of Stones

Description: Pick up three stones. Arbitrarily choose one as the king. Let its status feel completely serious for a few seconds. About ten seconds later, depose it and choose another king.

Normally:

Object → Ordinary object → Stable importance

The exercise briefly becomes:

Object → Arbitrary importance → New arbitrary importance

A large part of perceptual organization depends on implicit hierarchies. Some things feel important, others unimportant. Once a hierarchy is established, attention tends to treat it as meaningful and stable.

This exercise temporarily creates a hierarchy with no underlying justification. One stone becomes the king for no reason. For a few seconds, the designation is treated as entirely real. Then the hierarchy is dissolved and reassigned elsewhere.

For example:

Stone A → King

Ten seconds later:

Stone B → King

Nothing has changed about the stones themselves. Only their assigned status has changed.

The goal is not humor, irony, or absurdity. The temporary status should feel genuine while it lasts. The exercise works best when the designation is accepted rather than analyzed.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise weakens the automatic assumption that salience, importance, and priority must emerge from objective relevance. By creating and removing importance arbitrarily, it briefly decouples attention from utility and goal structure. The "king" becomes salient without recruiting any meaningful action sequence.

Exercise: Micro-Movement + No Comparison

Description: Perform a small arbitrary movement, then do not compare the situation before and after the movement.

For example:

- Slightly move a finger.
- Adjust posture a little.
- Shift gaze briefly.
- Move the mouse a few centimeters.
- Take one slightly different step.

Afterward, do not evaluate whether anything changed, improved, worsened, felt different, or produced an effect.

Normally:

Movement → Check result → Evaluation → Conclusion

The exercise briefly becomes:

Movement → It happened → Continue

Many actions automatically recruit comparison. As soon as something changes, the mind begins checking:

- Did that help?
- Do I feel different?
- Was it useful?
- Is there an effect?
- Should I do it again?

The movement itself is often trivial. Most of the recruitment comes from the evaluation process that follows.

This exercise leaves the movement intact while interrupting the comparison phase. The movement occurs, but it is not converted into evidence, feedback, progress, or failure.

In terms of next action pressure, the exercise targets one of the main mechanisms by which actions recruit further actions:

Action → Evaluation → Adjustment → New action

becomes:

Action → Continue

Because no result is extracted, the movement is less likely to generate optimization, repetition, or correction loops. The action remains local rather than becoming the start of a self-improvement sequence.

Exercise: Alter Your Path (RPG)

Description: Whenever a movement plan begins to feel established, introduce a small arbitrary deviation. For example, circle a harmless object, take a short detour, or alter your trajectory for a moment before resuming normal movement. The deviation should remain brief.

Normally:

Destination → Route selection → Prediction → Continuous movement

The exercise briefly becomes:

Destination → Route selection → Arbitrary deviation → Continue

The goal is not randomness, inefficiency, or confusion. The destination remains unchanged. Only the continuity of the movement sequence is briefly interrupted.

In terms of next action pressure, movement often serves as a carrier for future-oriented cognition. As the character moves, the mind naturally projects upcoming actions, evaluates possible routes, anticipates encounters, and prepares future decisions. By inserting a small deviation, the exercise weakens the automatic transition from current movement to predicted future movement.

Because movement opportunities occur constantly in RPGs, this exercise can be performed repeatedly throughout a play session. Unlike many other suspension exercises that are used occasionally, Alter Your Path can become a general-purpose intervention whenever a movement sequence begins recruiting plans, predictions, or optimization.

A simple way to use these exercises is to treat **Alter Your Path** as the default. You may then add **one openness exercise** and **one salience exercise**, performed much more sparingly. .

Reference:

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>
<https://florianmorin.com/papers/regime-of-joy/>